

3 MINUTES TO GET OUT: THE ALARM, THE DOOR, THE PLAN

Your grandparents had about 17 minutes. The fixes that put minutes back cost under 20 dollars.

The fire did not get faster. The furniture did. A modern couch is polyurethane foam made from petroleum. It melts into a pool fire and pours out smoke loaded with carbon monoxide and hydrogen cyanide. Your grandparents' couch was wood, cotton, and wool, and it burned like a log. Most people who die in house fires never get burned. The smoke gets them, usually while still asleep.

THE CLOCK

3 1/2 min

Modern furnished room to flashover in the Underwriters Laboratories test. The legacy room took about 29.

17 vs 3

Minutes people planned around to get out a generation ago, versus about 3 today.

Half

Of home fire deaths come from fires that start between 11 at night and 7 in the morning.

3 in 5

Home fire deaths in homes with no smoke alarm, or one that did not work. A working alarm cuts your odds of dying about in half.

THE DOOR TEST

Open

Past a thousand degrees at the ceiling, carbon monoxide ten thousand parts per million. Dead in minutes.

Closed

Under 100 degrees, carbon monoxide around 100 parts per million. A room you can breathe in long enough to get out.



Same hallway fire. The closed door keeps the bedroom on the old clock.

ALARM LAYOUT, 10 TO 20 DOLLARS EACH

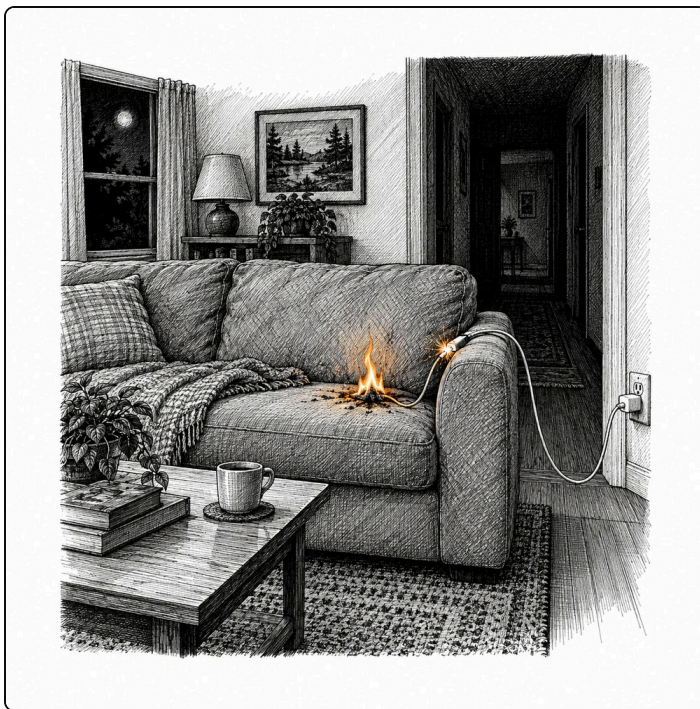
- ☐ One inside every bedroom.
- ☐ One outside each sleeping area.
- ☐ One on every floor.
- ☐ Sealed ten year battery, so nobody robs it for the remote.
- ☐ Interconnected if you can, so one sets off all of them.
- ☐ Check the date on the back. The sensor wears out at 10 years.
- ☐ Press the test button once a month.

THE DOOR DRILL

- 1** Close before you doze. Every bedroom door, every night. Kids too; use a monitor if you need to hear them.
- 2** Alarm goes off: do not open the door to go look.
- 3** Put the back of your hand on the door.
- 4** Hot: the hallway is gone. The window is your exit.
- 5** Cool: open it a crack, staying low, and check for smoke. Smoke means close it and go to the window.
- 6** Clear: go low and fast, and close the door behind you.

TWO WAYS OUT PLAN

- ☐ Two ways out of every room, and everyone knows both.
- ☐ Upstairs: a window you can actually open, and a rope ladder, 30 to 50 dollars, under the bed.
- ☐ A meeting spot outside, a mailbox or a tree. Nobody goes back in.
- ☐ Once out, call the fire department from a neighbor's, and stay out.
- ☐ Run the drill twice a year, in the dark.



A charger on the couch arm. The spark lands on foam.



Two ways out, a ladder under the bed, a meeting spot at the mailbox.

THE HONEST LIMITS

- ☐ **A closed door is a delay, not a wall.** Most interior doors are hollow. It buys the minutes you need to reach a window, not the night.
- ☐ **It does nothing if the fire starts in your room.** A space heater against the bed, a phone charging under the pillow, a candle.
- ☐ **The floor is on the modern clock too.** An unprotected I joist floor failed in about 6 minutes in an Underwriters Laboratories burn.
- ☐ **You do not need to throw the couch out.** Flame retardant foam barely slowed the fire in real tests. The door and the alarm buy the minutes.

Watch the full video: youtube.com/@SketchySurvival101

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Sketchy Survival 101. Physics first survival. Every number on this sheet comes straight from the video. Prices move, so check the current listing. A closed door is a delay, not a wall. The plan is get out, not fight it.